



The Ephemeris



December 2023

Volume 34 Number 04 - The Official Publication of the San Jose Astronomical Association

December 2023 - March 2024 Events

Schedule subject to change

Please check our website for up to date information:

Board & Speaker Talk

Saturday 12/2, 1/27, 2/24, 3/23

Board Meetings: 6 -7:30pm

Speaker Talk: 8-9:30pm

Solar Sunday (1:30-3:30pm)

Sunday 12/3, 1/7, 2/4, 3/3

Intro to the Night Sky & In-Town Star Party

Friday 12/15, 1/12, 2/9, 3/8

RCDO Starry Nights Star Party

Saturday 12/9, 1/6, 2/3, 3/2

Imaging SIG Mtg(Online)

Tuesday 12/12, 1/16, 2/20, 3/19

Binocular Star Gazing

Will resume in Summer 2024

Please refer to the SJAA Website home page (www.sjaa.net) and click on any "Upcoming Event" highlighted in Blue. It will take you to the SJ-Astronomy Meetup page (www.meetup.com/SJ-Astronomy/events/) where you can find specific event times, locations, maps and possible cancellation due to weather.

INSIDE THIS ISSUE

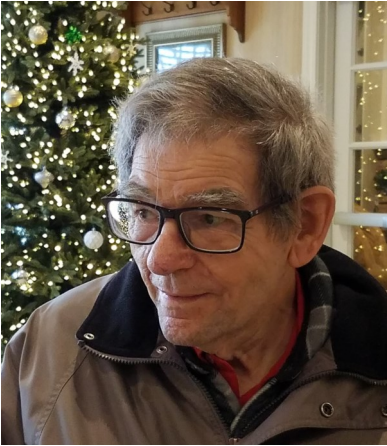
The Passing of a Legend ...	2
Articles	4
Astro Photos	9
Articles	13
Kids Spot	17
Board of Directors	18
Club Programs	19
Membership Form	20

Fish Head Nebula
Photo by SJAA Member: **Francesco Meschia**
November 11 2023
Location: Mountain View, CA



The Passing of an SJAA Legend

Credit: Rob Jaworski



On the eve of the American annular eclipse of October 2023, the members of SJAA were provided with some sad news. We learned that long time SJAA member Jim Van Nuland passed away earlier in the month.

Jim joined up with the SJAA in the mid-1970s, maybe earlier. He served many roles on the board and in officer positions, but most notably he was the incredible energy of the School Star Party program. Indeed, for decades Jim **was** the School Star Party program. During the school year Jim and his crew were out on some elementary, middle school or high school campus showing the wonders of the night sky to every next generation. He would schedule so many SSPs, sometimes three a week, sometimes seven. It kept him busy and he loved it. His only breaks were around the full moon when he was able to convince eager parents and administrators that they really don't want to look at a 98% lit moon through a telescope. Sometimes he couldn't convince them and so out he went. Jim kept at it until he was physically unable to carry it on any longer and finally retired in 2018.

The family posted this obituary online, but we have pasted it below as well.

<https://danerimortuary.com/tribute/details/324140/James-Van-Nuland/obituary.html>

James "Jim" Henry Van Nuland, 87, of Little Chute, and Tigerton Wisconsin, passed away on September 30, 2023, in Folsom, California. Born on September 14, 1936, Jim was the eldest son of the late Jacob and Verna Van Nuland.

Jim had a fulfilling life and left behind a loving family. He is survived by his sons Patrick, Raymond, Thomas, and Michael, and his "Favorite Daughter," Barbara. His sisters Joan and Rosemary are also blessedly still with us.

Jim was gifted with 16 grandchildren, 12 great-grandchildren, and countless fans and friends who gravitated toward his kindness, and some would say, innocence. He was preceded in death by his beloved wife of 44 years, Florence-Anna, who passed away in 2004.

After completing high school in 1954, Jim proudly served in the US Navy for 3 years, completing 2 scientific tours to Antarctica, and mapping the ocean floor east of Florida, over which all of NASA's rockets would eventually take off.

Following his military service, Jim enrolled at Marquette University to study Electrical Engineering but was in the end, "drafted" by IBM to become a Programmer where he dedicated 25 years of his life, earning a 30-year credited early retirement. His expertise and hard work made a significant impact on the company, even to this day.

He was one of the first "civilians" with a personal computer during the '70s, and instilled the "tech-bug" in his kids as early as he could.

It was early in college when he double-dated with his sister, and her date and met Florence, -whom he was then forever enamored with, married, and had 5 children. 2 born in Wisconsin, 2 in Southern California, and saving the "best" one, born last in San Jose California, where he lived since 1966.

In his free time, Jim pursued his passion for astronomy and spent many hours sharing his knowledge as a 40-year member of the San Jose Amateur Astronomy Association, with over an estimated 100,000 children over the decades. He was a curious man who found joy in exploring the wonders of the universe and sharing it with everyone. He claimed he was "Paid with wows" when asked about any compensation for his tireless efforts. He was paid well. May he rest in peace, and his skies be always clear.

Jim's faith played an important role in his life, sending his children to Catholic schools, and was a long-time member of Saint Lucy's Catholic Church.

Services for Jim Van Nuland will be announced at a later date. His legacy will live on through his family, friends, and all those whose lives he touched.



Jay Reynolds Freeman, upon hearing about Jim's demise, wrote the following.

I remember Jim well -- he and his eight-inch equatorially-mounted Newtonian were regular fixtures at SJAA events during the several decades in which I was an active local member.

Astronomy folks may be less familiar with his experiences in computer science, which he occasionally mentioned while waiting for sunset or for transient clouds to pass. I remember a time in the late 1990s, when Jim told of the scorn with which IBM management greeted his mid-1960s suggestion that it would be unwise to use only two digits for years in text strings representing dates, because some day the calendar would roll through a century year, the digits would wrap around, and confusion might arise thereby. It did, and the "Y2K" problem was the result. Jim also convinced computer operators that yes, it was indeed possible for a programmer to cause serious physical damage to a mainframe computer, supposedly safe in its isolated room, merely by running code: His program used the track-seek function on a large, heavy, early disk drive to slam the read-write head between its radial limits at a varying rate. When that rate matched the resonant frequency for lateral oscillations of the entire drive unit, cabinet and all, that unit started walking across the floor of the computer room and eventually tipped over.

Rest in peace, Jim ...

-- Jay Reynolds Freeman

The family thought it would be appropriate to hold a celebration of Jim's life at Houge Park, the SJAA basecamp for so many years (and club lore has it that Jim had a hand in securing the park for the club sometime in the 1990s). Of course it was most appropriate, and several current club members helped to host the event there, which was very well attended. Marianne Damon, the SJAA refreshments lead, was able to attend both the funeral and the life celebration. These are her words.

The funeral mass was held on Monday, October 23 at his parish church, St. Lucy's. Several SJAA members attended in support of the family. The urn chosen was of a nebular design and made us smile, knowing he would have approved of the choice. The organist who played did so lovingly, as Jim would always go up and thank her and the choir after each mass.

The family asked to have the post-funeral gathering at Houge Park, and SJAA was able to host this event. We opened the hall and set up tables with the family before the funeral. They had requested that, if possible, they be able to see the two telescopes they had donated, and we were able to oblige. Two of Jim's sons brought them out from behind the curtain and set them up. JVN's daughter Barbara recalled how the big white 8" dob got its name: "When the big 8" stood in the backyard all those years, wrapped up in layers protected from the elements, it reminded Mom of Ruth Buzzi's bag lady character from the Laugh-In TV show: Gladys." After the funeral, family and friends gathered at Houge Hall and reminisced about our adventures with Jim. The family had set up a memorial table to which we added the trophy given by the City of San Jose for service to the community, mostly for his years of providing school star parties. The family provided Jim's favorite snacks and lunch items. We concluded the gathering with thoughts of a fond farewell to our astronomy friend and mentor, JVN.

As the SJAA's sole two-time recipient of the Gregory Award (1984 and 2007), the club's highest honor, Jim was held in high regard and he will continue to be. With his passing the club turns a chapter in its history, moving from an organization started in the mid-twentieth century with the awe inspired by the launch of Sputnik and the myriad NASA programs, to the twenty-first century where professional space science (and computer science!) continues. The SJAA will carry on as Jim would want, to provide a space for like minded individuals to gather as well as to provide a place where the next generation of enthusiasts (and hopefully scientists and engineers) can find a foothold.

Thank you for everything you did, Jim.



Jim Van Nuland (left) and Gordon Reade (right) accept an award on behalf of SJAA from San Jose's District 9 councilmember Judy Chirco (center).



Our Annual Report to the City of San Jose

Credit: Marianne Damon

The following is taken from the annual October 2022 to September 2023 report submitted to the City of San Jose, Parks, Recreation & Neighborhood Services. This is our first annual report to include results from our new sign-in sheets and satisfaction surveys. The ratings and public comments show that our programs are popular and valuable!

Describe any major accomplishment (s) from this quarter in achieving the program goals:

We were able to get internet access to the hall via a hotspot. This allows for hybrid lecture programs utilizing remote guest speakers.

The QuickStart program now has a leader and is fully operational, holding the educational portion of the program at the site.

Our loaner program has also moved back into the hall and is fully operational.

We have established sign-in sheets and satisfaction surveys for people who attend the live events at the site.

We have posted our hours on the marquee for the public to view at any time at the site.

We have contacted all schools in the 95124 zip-code area and offered them information about our School Star Party program.

Performance Measures, General (for all Center programs)

85% of participants will rate services as "good" or "excellent": Our SJAA Client Satisfaction Surveys came in at 100%

75% of participants served will be San José residents: According to our SJAA Client Satisfaction Surveys 70% of participants live in the targeted zip codes.

85% will rate the Center as being clean and well maintained: Our SJAA Client Satisfaction Surveys came in at 100%. Some facilities issues were noted, as listed below.

Performance Measures, Specific to Your Program:

All ratings were good or excellent, and so the results for each program were 100%. Results are based on 95 satisfaction surveys received.

Solar Viewing: 85% of participants will rate services as "good" or "excellent": Results = 100%

In Town Star Party: 85% of participants will rate services as "good" or "excellent": Results = 100%

Astronomy 101/Intro to Astronomy: 85% of participants will rate services as "good" or "excellent": Results = 100%

Speaker Night/General Meeting: 85% of participants will rate services as "good" or "excellent": Results = 100%

Comments regarding the facility:

"Ventilation could be better at the venue."

"City of San Jose, please provide air conditioning for these events."

"Some lights were not functioning though."

Comments regarding User Specific Programs:

Sample Comments for **Solar Viewing**:

"Very interesting, technically excellent & well explained for me. Very cool!"

"What a treat!"

"Very nice experience"

Sample Comments for **In Town Star Party**:

"Good variety of scopes. I liked the laser talk! Friendly and knowledgeable docents helped us to learn more about the night sky."

"Great info. Lot of People & great energy all around."

"Had a blast!!"



Sample Comments for **Astronomy 101/Intro to Astronomy**:

"Great introductory lecture. The speaker was engaging & enthusiastic."

"Speaker's content was accommodating to people of all knowledge levels and interests."

"Thank you for your patience for audience questions & comments."

"Wolf was a great speaker and the presentation was fun & engaging."

Sample Comments for **Speaker Night/General Meeting**:

"Great talk & organization of the event. Fantastic! I hope many more events to come, Super!" re: Science & Technology at Lick Observatory

"Terrific presentation by Dr. Elinor Gates"

"I had no idea there is so much cool science going on at Lick! I'll definitely be up for one evening viewing."

"Engaging speaker & topic! re: Gravity Waves

"Concise, easy to follow, speaker knowledgeable and clear in his discussion."

"Very nice talk and homey atmosphere" re: How to Photograph an Eclipse

"Really enjoyed the information about eclipse photography"

"The organizer did a very good job setting up seats and AV equipment. Very nice facility"

Thanks go to Rob Jaworski, Renuka Veeraswamy, and Marianne Damon for collecting and entering calendar and statistical data each month and preparing the mid-year and annual reports.



Dr Elinor Gates from Lick Observatory speaks at Houge Park on 6th of May

From Left to Right: Vini Carter, Leslie Carter, Marianne Damon, Rob Jaworski, Dr. Elinor Gates, Peter Melhus, Michael Mark and Chris Gottbrath

Credit: Bo Song



Scientific Process At Work and The Formation Of Our Solar System

Credit: Jordan Makower



Image from www.tweaktown.com

Nicolaus Copernicus, in 1543, proposed the idea that planets orbited the Sun, in seeking to find a simple model to account for his observations and the re-evaluation existing data about the irregular movements of planets. A few decades after that, Tycho Brahe collected much greater amounts of measurements on planetary motions which supported the Copernican Theory. That data eventually fell into the hands of Johannes Kepler, who formulated his 3 Laws of Planetary Motion (Elliptic orbits, Equal Areas Swept by Planets in Equal Time, Relationship between a Planet's revolution and its distance from the Sun). Each of these people had never used a telescope. When Galileo adapted telescopic observations to his predecessors' work, the issue of planetary movements was *scientifically settled*.

Over 100 years later, Immanuel Kant, building on work done by other scientists, proposed a Nebular Hypothesis, in which gaseous clouds move and gravitationally collapse to form stars and planets. In 1796, Pierre-Simon Laplace proposed a more detailed model considering the formation of our Sun and planets.

This is how 'scientific process' works; observations lead to unifying ideas (theories), which are tested and accepted or rejected, based on data collected. Theories are revised as new information is obtained, and our understanding of our environment is improved, even if not completely explained.

In order to explain the features we observe in our Solar System; size/composition of Sun and planets, planetary rings, moons, asteroids, magnetic/energy fields, comets..., we apply all the data we have gathered to understand its process of formation.

Our Solar System has formed, and is forming, from the gravitational compaction of matter generated by the last cloud of debris from previous nearby supernovas, which produced the 118 chemical elements existing in our 'neighborhood' today. NASA and other scientific organizations around the world continue to collect data to aid in a more complete picture of our surroundings. Be alert for new discoveries to improve our 'model'.

SJAA wishes its members Happy Holidays and Best Wishes for a Happy New Year 2024!



On the Road: Annular Eclipse Viewing From Battle Mountain Nevada

Credit: Joe Fragola

By now, the excitement over the annular Solar eclipse on October 14 has subsided. As the date for the eclipse approached astronomy enthusiasts, and the public in general, made plans on where to best view the eclipse. Given that the date for the eclipse fell on a Saturday, local eclipse watchers had some flexibility in deciding whether to remain at home in the Bay Area to view a partial eclipse, or travel for an opportunity to view totality. The SJAA Observers Google group captured posts about the SJAA-sponsored viewing at Houge Park, SJAA support of an eclipse viewing party in Palo Alto organized by Stanford University, as well as separate plans being made by SJAA Members.

Those traveling to view the eclipse had concerns about two key factors – lodging and weather. As it turned out a small contingent from SJAA gathered in the small community of Battle Mountain, Nevada. This location is a bit over 200 miles east of Reno, about a 3-hour drive by car. The town was hosting an eclipse viewing party in Elquist Park, a nice grassy area located between their Recreation Center and the High School. At one point, the size of the SJAA group planning to watch from Battle Mountain was 9 Members. Due to concerns over the weather forecast on Eclipse Day, a few Members made alternate plans. In the end, SJAA representation totaled 5 Members (plus two family members).



SJAA group in Battle Mountain (left to right: Marianne's sister Jan, Karen Bieber, Marianne Damon, Vignesh Balaji, Milind Girkar, Joe Fragola. Not pictured: Debbie Fragola who took the picture.)

On the morning of the eclipse, we woke up to completely cloudy skies. The SJAA group gathered in the park by 7:30 a.m. Prospects for viewing didn't look good. There were breaks in the clouds and some patches of blue sky toward the south/southeast. The clouds were moving slowly, in the right direction to give us an opportunity to eventually see an unobscured Sun. But it still wasn't certain whether we would get an opportunity to view totality or not. The race was between slowly moving clouds, and orbital mechanics bringing the Sun-Moon-Earth alignment closer.



From our location, the eclipse began at 8:08 a.m. Our first break came around 8:30 a.m. when we were able to view the Sun in a partial eclipse. Partly cloudy sky conditions continued for the next 50 minutes with the cloud cover seeming to thin out a bit as time went on. Luckily, we had enough of a break to view the 4 minutes and 18 seconds of totality between 9:20 am and 9:24 a.m. After that, we were back to intermittent clouds for a while as we watched the partial phase as the Moon finished crossing the Sun.

Marianne was the most prepared among us, having several pair of binoculars with solar filters which she shared with the group. The best views were through her tripod-mounted 16 x 70 binoscope. In addition to those of us who did not have observing equipment, many of the other eclipse watchers were very appreciative of the views Marianne shared through her binoscope. Sometimes a little patience was required as the Sun/Moon played hide and seek behind a passing cloud. The local tourism bureau had planned for eclipse shades to be given out "one per family". Upon learning of this, Karen and Marianne brought lots of extras so everyone could have a pair. Luckily, when the clouds parted for our first view, everyone was able to look at the same time. Everyone had a chance at a great view, including several sun-spot groups during the partial phases of the eclipse through Marianne's setup.



(Photo by Vignesh Balaji using a Galaxy smartphone with a solar filter covering the lenses.)

With the October eclipse behind us, the cosmic clock continues to tick. If you missed the annular Solar eclipse, you still have the opportunity to experience a total Solar eclipse on April 8, 2024. Here's a link to help with planning for this eclipse. <https://nationaleclipse.com/maps.html>

Once again, the Bay Area will be outside the path of totality, so a road trip will be necessary for the next eclipse. At the time of writing this article (late October), it's already getting late to find lodging for this eclipse. As you are reading this in the December issue of The Ephemeris, reservations are even more scarce with the event only 4 months away.

Happy eclipse viewing everyone and good luck with the weather and lodging wherever you choose to watch.



Partial Solar Eclipse

Nikola Nikolov



Dates: Oct 14, 2023

Location: Houge Park, San Jose CA

Imaging Telescope: Astro-Tech AT130EDT

Imaging Camera: ZWO ASI120MC

Mount: Orion Sirius EQ-G

Software: ZWO ASIcap, NINA



SJAA Member Astrophoto Gallery



Date: October 20, 2023

Location: Palo Alto, CA

Telescope: Celestron EdgeHD 11"

Camera: ZWO ASI2600 MC Pro

Mount: Astro-Physics Mach2 GTO

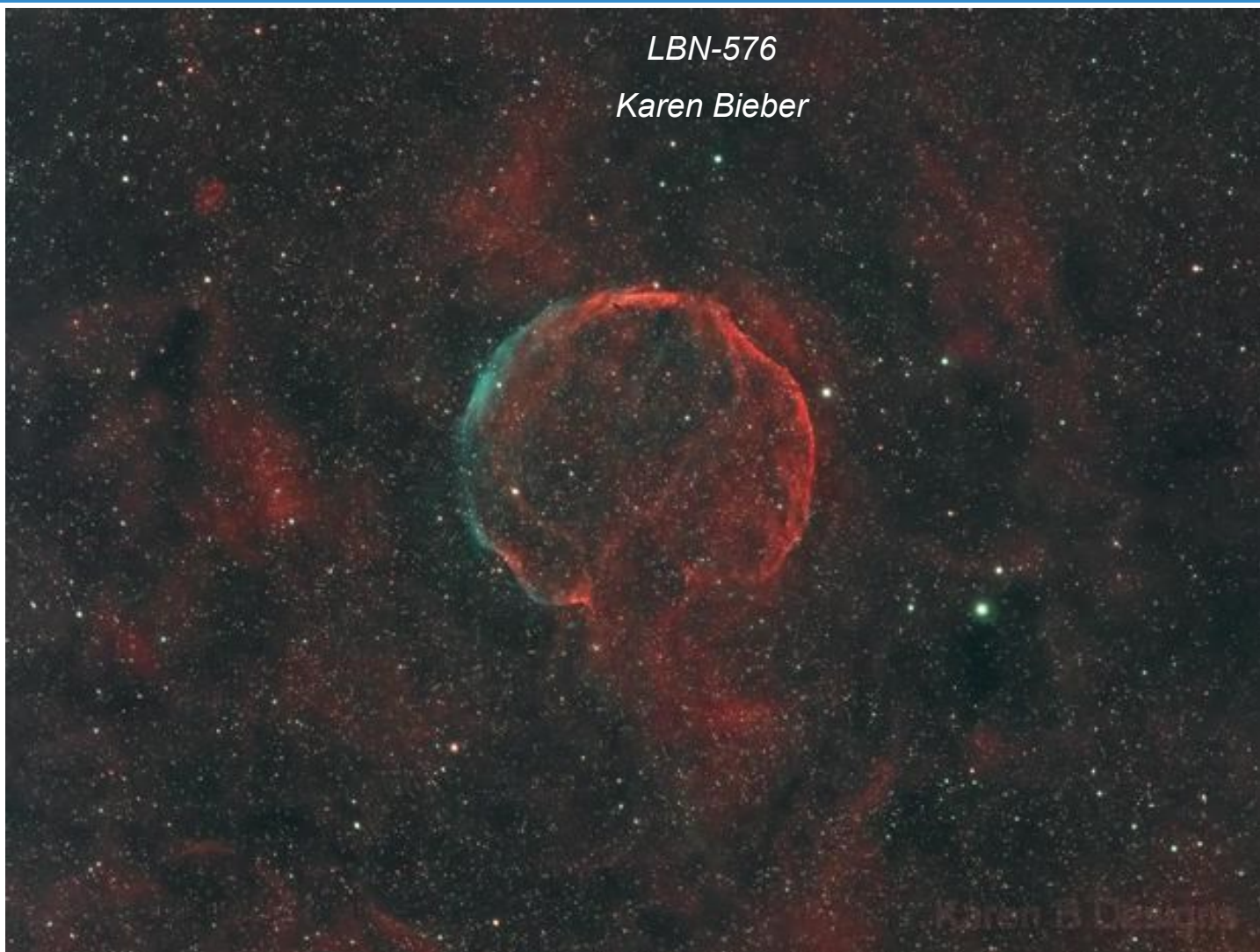
Software: PHD2, PixInsight, Lightroom 6.4, Sequence Generator Pro



SJAA Member Astrophoto Gallery

LBN-576

Karen Bieber



Date: October 20, 2023

Location: Cow Hill Observatory, Morgan Hill, California, United States

Telescope: William Optics Fluorostar 91 / FLT91

Camera: ZWO ASI2600MC Pro

Mount: ZWO AM5

Software: Adobe Photoshop, Pleiades Astrophoto PixInsight



Oct 14th Partial Eclipse Event in Houge Park

Credit: Chris Gottbrath

On Oct 14th we hosted a very successful public viewing of the partial eclipse that was visible from San Jose. We had about 300 people join us at Houge Park to see the eclipse through eclipse glasses as well as through the many telescopes we made available.



*Image by: Christos Gougoussis. A diverse crowd takes in eclipse at Houge Park
(Attendee faces have been blurred here and in other images to preserve privacy.)*

Weather was a challenge, indeed the first part of the ellipse at around 8:10 was fairly obscured by clouds. However there were breaks which, I suppose, added a bit to the drama. I was delighted to hear the crowd react each time the clouds parted and some folks could see the eclipse for the first time while others got a chance to see how much more of the sun was obscured by the moon.

As the morning progressed, the cloud cover broke up a bit and from mid-eclipse at 9:20 on we had a pretty consistent view with only a few lengthy interruptions.

While the eclipse itself was an annular eclipse, the path of annularity passed north and east of San Jose (touching just the far north east corner of California) so we got to see a pretty respectable partial eclipse. We set up the event to allow participants to see the eclipse as it was happening for us locally and also be able to watch live streams of the view from other locations along the path of annularity.

I want to make sure this article thanks all the folks who volunteered to make the event a success. I need to start with Radhika Gupta who stepped forward and helped out across the whole event. Planning and executing the morning's activity took thought and effort and it was fantastic to be able to count on a strong co-leader.



We organized our activities in two spaces, inside the meeting room and outside near the tennis courts and I'll use that structure to talk here about what we did.

We used the meeting room space to introduce SJAA and the eclipse. Emi Nikolov shared info about SJAA and helped folks sign in – then directed them inside where Alex Colias was acting as a sort of MC for everything going on. He in turn directed them to Michael Mark and Rich Klein who were handing out eclipse glasses (with safety instructions) and explaining the eclipse images that were being streamed from telescopes outside in the park as well as from along the path of annularity. Peter Melhus and Snehal Shinde had food, drink, and solar beads available for those interested. On their way back outside to take in the eclipse with their glasses, participants had the opportunity to see and interact with a scale model demonstration of the eclipse that Gary Mitchell organized.



Emi



Alex and Michael



Rich



Crowd Shot



Jon and Snehal



Gary

Images by: Radhika Gupta

Feedback from the volunteers running things inside the meeting room were that it was really helpful to have the live streams, that folks came in a few at a time so it was a little challenging to organize and present information to them, and that not everyone came inside so the folks there didn't feel like they had a chance to interact with the full crowd.

Then once they came outside participants had the opportunity to take in the eclipse with eclipse glasses as well as through a variety of telescopes. Christos Gougoussis, Larry Zurbrick, Bob Thompson, Natti Pierce-Thompson, Komal Bhardwaj, and Vini Carter all offered eyepiece views while Nikola Nikolov, Glenn Newell, Ken Miura, and I had various digital cameras attached to our scopes. Nikola and I also supplied our images via streaming to be available for display in the meeting room.



Bob and Natti



Ken



Vini





Nikola



Larry



Snehal and Chris

Images by: Radhika Gupta

Feedback from folks outside included that some of the observing locations were obscured by a tree. We'd noted it as a concern but didn't carve out quite enough of the space when we created the planning map for folks setting up their scopes. Another bit of feedback was that we needed more ways (stools, ladders) to help kids get in good positions to look at the eyepieces of various scopes.

Glenn Newell has a custom Wi-Fi based image streaming solution that he has been developing. He set that up and with a couple of QR codes attendees could use their phones to attach to his Wi-Fi and then point their browsers to his stream. This technique supports a relatively large number of folks being able to see what his telescope is observing at one time. This has potential application to public observing sessions and contrasts with what you get from some of the EAA solutions that typically only allow a single device to connect at a time.

I used a portable Wi-Fi hotspot (a Netgear Nighthawk M6 on AT&T) to provide Wi-Fi coverage out near the telescopes. Nikola Nikolov and I connected our computers to that Wi-Fi which gave a stronger signal than the SJAA one in the building. We used the SJAA Zoom license to create a meeting and Nikola shared his telescope view in the Zoom meeting. I set up a live YouTube stream for my images. With both sources available Rich and the folks inside could choose either of our images to display on the screen. Working out the streaming and the projector setup took some practice. I got great advice and help on networking and streaming tech from Parag Shah during our prep sessions – Thanks Parag!

One thing that I learned the hard way during the event was that my manual equatorial mount, while fine for tracking the sun during a normal observing run without clouds, didn't perform well during the eclipse. With the intermittent clouds I lost track of the sun multiple times and then getting it back involved switching back to a low power eyepiece and then having to refocus for the camera. That meant my livestream had gaps when I wasn't showing the eclipse. Luckily Nikola's tracking mount was better able to follow the sun even when it was behind a cloud. We don't have a recording of the Zoom but edited a version of my live stream to skip or speed through the time spent re-acquiring the sun which you can look up by searching YouTube for "Chris Gottbrath Eclipse Edited".

Here are a few images from that stream showing the eclipse, sunspots, and the clouds. Color image by Nikola and in monochrome by the author.



Early eclipse with clouds



*Eclipse near the maximum,
also with a bit of cloud.*



*End of the eclipse, also
with a bit of cloud.*

Images by Chris Gottbrath



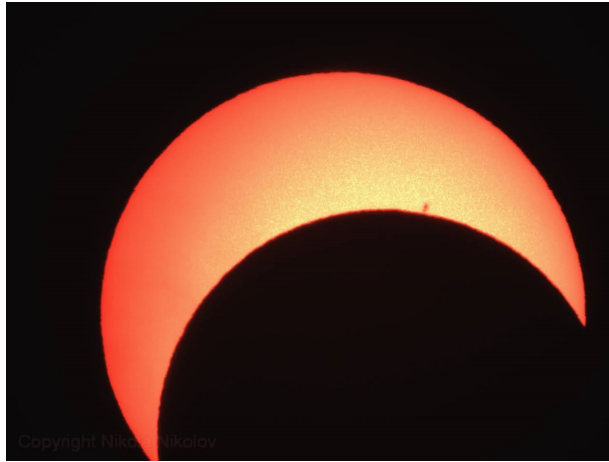


Image by Nikola Nikolov

In addition to running telescopes and scale models and projectors we had a number of people who volunteered to be around to help participants. I really appreciate those volunteers as well as everyone mentioned above: Jon Anderson, Albert Esquivel, Rob Jaworski, Arjun Jayaraman.

Kudos also to Beth Johnson for help with social media and Rob Jaworski for help with the finances. Muditha Kanchana and Marianne Damon weren't able to make it on eclipse day but helped out with equipment and advice prior to the event.

Wolf Witt and Nancy Lieu organized a parallel event at KIPAC in Stanford but they were really gracious to help with planning and sharing equipment.

I tried to catch everyone, but am aware that I probably missed at least a few folks who contributed insight, energy and enthusiasm to the event. Thanks to all who helped out in small and large ways.

Shortly after the event I sent around an email to the volunteers asking about memories of the event. This is a compilation of some of the answers that came back.

- The reaction when folks first saw the eclipse
- Seeing the crescent eclipse shadows under the tree (always something I love about partial eclipses)
- The line for Bob and Natti's solar scope
- The view from Glenn's new Seestar scope
- A close up look at prominences that I happened to see in Nikola's live stream
- Of course, the eyepiece view of the eclipse at near maximum where I could clearly see the prominences, sun-spots, eclipse and clouds.
- There was indeed a child-like thrill precisely when the moon started coming in front of the sun. Although we knew this would happen, and precisely when it will happen - but that first nibble of the sun by the moon was so joyful.
- The excitement of kids and adults when they saw the details through eyepiece - "oh so cool", "wow", "this is so nice"
- Explaining that those "spots" are not because my lenses are dirty - but it's because the sun has those spots
- Seeing the prominences through 150mm Lunt telescope
- Children's excited chatter while viewing the crescent sun through their solar glasses
- The live view from TX of the ring of fire

The feedback that we got from attendees on the meetup platform was positive with a 5/5 rating with 13 responses. 10/13 said it was engaging, 8/13 said we provided a welcoming host and that it was a good setting, 7/13 said it made an impact, and 4/13 said they met new people. Aishwarya J left a thank you note "Thank you for organizing this event. Appreciated the amazing volunteers who were so passionate and patient and also thank you for being so thoughtful and providing water and breakfast bars." Joseph W said "Thanks everyone for organizing! This was a great event which my son & I both enjoyed very much!"

Overall I would say it was a great eclipse experience and I am happy that the association was able to rally around the idea of doing a local event.





Kid Spot Jokes:

Q: Why does the moon orbit the Earth?

A: To get to the other side??

Q: How do astronomers organize a party?

A: They planet.

Q: What music do Astronauts listen to?

A: Nep-Tunes!

A Name Change

Credit: Marianne Damon

The International Dark-Sky Association (IDA) has changed its name to DarkSky International. So instead of IDA, think DarkSky!

Awareness of the importance of dark skies continues to grow, and DarkSky is the main driver of educating people at the local, regional and international levels. In the United States they partner with the National Park Service, Audubon, National Science Foundation, United Nations Office for Outer Space Affairs, the Illuminating Engineering Society (IES), and the International Commission of Illumination. How effective have they been? A listing of their 2023 accomplishments mention certifying ten new International Dark Sky Places, including the first in mainland China; enrolling new DarkSky chapters in Argentina, Brazil, Uruguay, New Mexico, and Kenya (the first on the African continent); reaching one billion people (!) during International Dark Sky Week; and hosting Under One Sky, a global 24-hour virtual conference.

Of interest, DarkSky hosts an online monthly presentation called Night Matters. The speaker for the recent November 15th event titled Festivals of Light was Michael Marlin, a long-time advocate for dark sky education. He has just written the first book on the growing interest in “star tourism”, *Astrotourism: Star Gazers, Eclipse Chasers, and the Dark Sky Movement*. He is also working to produce a one-hour weekly television series, *The Astrotourist*, “which takes a deep cultural dive into humanity’s relationship with the stars and how light pollution is impacting the biosphere across the planet.”



Credit: DarkSky International website



From the Board of Directors

Announcements

- ◇ New board member elections will be held at the February 2024 board meeting on February 24. The following 4 board positions will be open for Elections: Director 2, Director 4, Director 6, and Director 8. All current incumbents are expected to run for their positions again. Any member interested in running for these positions should reach out to the Secretary at secretary@sjaa.net for eligibility criteria and other details.
- ◇ New officer elections for President, Vice-President, Treasurer and Secretary positions will be held at the March 2024 board meeting on March 23. Any member interested in running for these positions should reach out to the Secretary at secretary@sjaa.net for eligibility criteria and other details.
- ◇ Open Positions: Intro to the Night Sky/Astronomy 101, Library, Guest Speaker program coordinator.
- ◇ Current SJAA Members can benefit from signing up for the "SJ Astronomy" group on Meetup (<https://www.meetup.com/sj-astronomy/>) as well as the "SJAA Observers" Google group (<https://groups.google.com/g/sjaa-observers>).
- ◇ Calling All SJAA Members! The February 24th meeting is our annual Elections and Member Recognition Pot-Luck. Join your astronomy friends in person to elect board members, applaud those who receive awards, share a meal, and have some good visiting time. Family and friends are welcome, too! See you at 7:30, just after the Board meeting!

Board Meeting Excerpts

September 30, 2023

In attendance

Aroon, Chris, Ken, Rob J, Glenn, Wolf, Peter, Sukhada, Swami

Absences: Vini

Guests Larry Z, Marianne D, Snehal S, Prateek V, Emi N

SJAA Meetup Ownership

Sukhada will coordinate with Rob for

him to take over the ownership of SJAA Meetup.

Funds Request for Solar Program

Peter made a motion for Wolf to purchase items for the Solar Program. Glenn seconded. All approved, no abstentions or objections. Motion passed.

Reimbursement for Houge Park 10/14 Eclipse Activities

Rob made a motion to allow up to \$2000 for Chris to purchase the items related to the solar eclipse event at HP, as described above. Glenn seconded. All approved, no abstentions or objections. Motion carried.

Minors policy and Fingerprinting / Background Checks

SJAA board is working on having a Minors Policy in place that describes how SJAA deals with matters concerning minors attending SJAA events.

Lifetime Memberships

Swami made a motion to approve the Lifetime Membership Policy as written by Marianne and reviewed by the board. Sukhada seconded. All approved, no abstentions or objections. Motion carried. The Lifetime Membership policy has been adopted by SJAA as of September 30, 2023.

October 28, 2023

In attendance

Rob J, Sukhada, Wolf, Vini, Glenn, Peter, Aroon, Glenn

Absences: Ken, Chris, Swami,

Guest: Joe F, Emi N, Nikola N, Nancy L. Kanch, Leo L. Marianne D

2024 SJAA Calendar

Kanch and Joe did a preview of the 2024 SJAA calendar, and a walk through of the calendar update process with leaders.

Annular Eclipse Event at KIPAC

SJAA was invited by KIPAC (<https://kipac.stanford.edu/>) to participate in the October 14 annular solar eclipse. It was a successful event with +/- 3500 participants.

SJAA Meetup Ownership

Rob J. has taken over the ownership of the SJAA Meetup.

December 2, 2023

In attendance

Ken, Swami, Wolf, Aroon, Peter, Rob J

Absences: Glenn, Chris, Vini

Guests: Kanch, Emi, Larry Z, Leslie, Marianne, Michael, Satish

SJAA 2024 Calendar

Rob made a motion to approve the draft calendar prepared and shared by Kanch and Joe, with the edits proposed by the reviewers. Swami seconded. All approved, no abstentions or objections. Motion carried. The proposed calendar of events is now officially adopted by SJAA for 2024.

Switch our website hosting from Atlantic to SiteGround

Rob made a motion to approve an expense of up to \$500 for migrating our website hosting from Atlantic to SiteGround, as per the description and costs above. Aroon seconded. All approved, no abstentions or objections. Motion carried. Webmaster Satish may proceed to migrate the website hosting as per this motion, utilizing Mike's services for this purpose.

New FixIt Person

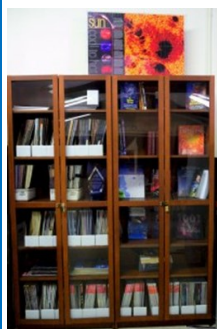
Larry Zurbick is the new Fix It program coordinator!! Congratulations Larry!

Sukhada Palav has resigned from Board position

Sukhada Palav has resigned from her Board position. This board position will temporarily be left open until the next board meeting on January 27th.



SJAA Library



SJAA offers another wonderful resource; a library with good astronomy books and DVDs available to all of our members that will interest all age groups and especially young children who are budding astronomers! You may still send all your questions/comments

to librarian@sjaa.net.

Telescope Fix It Session

Fix It Day, sometimes called the Telescope Tune Up or the Telescope Fix It program is a real simple service the SJAA offers to members of the community for free, though it's priceless. Headed up by Larry Zurbrick, the Fix It session provides a place for people to come with their telescope or other astronomy gear problems and have them looked at, such as broken scopes whose owners need advice, or need help with collimating a telescope.

<http://www.sjaa.net/programs/fixit/>

Solar Observing

Solar observing sessions, headed up by Wolf Witt, are usually held the 1st Sunday of every Month from 2pm - 4pm at Houge Park weather permitting. Please check SJ Astronomy Meetup for schedule details as the event time / location is subject to change.

<http://www.meetup.com/SJ-Astronomy/>

Quick STARt Program

The Quick STARt Program, headed up by Jonathan Lawton, helps to ease folks into amateur astronomy. You have to admit, astronomy can look exciting from the outside, but once you scratch the surface, it can get seemingly complex in a hurry. But it doesn't have to be that way if there's someone to guide you and answer all your seemingly basic questions.

The Quick Start sessions are generally held quarterly. The Quick Start program is currently on hold pending a leader stepping up to own the program.

<http://www.sjaa.net/programs/quick-start/>

Intro to the Night Sky

The Intro to the Night Sky session takes place monthly, in conjunction with first quarter moon and In Town Star Parties at Houge Park. This is a regular, monthly session, run by David Grover, each with a similar format, with only the content chang-

ing to reflect what's currently in the night sky. After the session, the attendees will go outside for a guided, green laser tour of the sky, along with views through SJAA Telescopes at the In-Town Star Party, to get a better look at the night's celestial objects.

<http://www.sjaa.net/programs/beginners-astronomy/>

Loaner Program

Muditha Kanchana (Kanch) heads up this program. The Program goal is for SJAA members to be able to evaluate equipment they are considering purchasing or are just curious about by checking out loaners from SJAA's growing list of equipment. Please note that certain items have restrictions or special conditions that must be met. If you are an SJAA member and an experienced observer or have been through the SJAA Quick STARt program please fill this form to request a particular item. Please also consider donating unused equipment.

<http://www.sjaa.net/programs/loaner-telescope-program/>

Astro Imaging Special Interest Group (SIG)

SIG has a mission of bringing together people who have an interest in astronomy imaging, or put more simply, taking pictures of the night sky. Run by Hy Murveit, the Imaging SIG meets roughly every month at Houge Park to discuss topics about imaging. The SIG is open to people with absolutely no experience but want to learn what it's all about, but experienced imagers are also more than welcome, indeed, encouraged to participate. The best way to get involved is to review the postings on the SJAA Astro Imaging mail list in Google Groups.

<http://www.sjaa.net/programs/imaging-sig/>

Astro Imaging Workshops and Field Clinics

Not to be confused with the SIG group this newly organized program championed by Glenn Newell is a hands on program for club members, who are interested in astrophotography, to have a chance of seeing what it is all about.

Workshops are held at Houge Park once per month and field clinics (members only) once per quarter at a dark sky site. Check the schedule and contact Glenn Newell if you are interested.

School Star Party

The San Jose Astronomical Association conducts evening observing sessions (commonly called "star parties") for schools in mid-Santa Clara County, generally from Sunnyvale to Fremont to Morgan Hill.

Contact SJAA's (Program Coordinator) for additional information.

<http://www.sjaa.net/programs/school-star-party/>

SJAA Contacts

President/Dir:	Aroon Nair
Vice President:	Chris Gottbrath
Treasurer/Dir:	Rob Jaworski
Secretary/Dir:	Swami Nigam
Director:	Vini Carter
Director:	Ken Miura
Director:	Glenn Newell
Director:	Wolf Witt
Director:	Vacant
Director:	Peter Melhus
Ephemeris Newsletter -	
Editor:	Abishek
Prod. Editor:	Emi Nikolov
Binocular Stargazing:	Ed Wong
Fix-it Program:	Larry Zurbrick
Hands on Imaging:	Glenn Newell
Imaging SIG:	Hy Murveit
Intro to the Night Sky:	Vacant
In-Town Star Party:	Muditha Kanchana
Library:	Vacant
Loaner Program:	Muditha Kanchana
Memberships:	Kaushal
Publicity:	Beth Johnson
Quick STARt	Jonathan Lawton
Donations:	Rich Gregor
Solar:	Wolf Witt
Starry Nights:	Joe Fragola
School Events:	Jon Anderson
Refreshments:	Marianne Damon
Social Manager:	Beth Johnson
Speakers:	Vacant
Webmaster:	Satish Vellanki
E-mails:	http://www.sjaa.net/contact

SJAA Ephemeris, the newsletter of the San Jose Astronomical Association, is published quarterly.

Articles, including Observation Reports for publication should be submitted by no later than the 20th of the month of February, May, August and November.

San Jose Astronomical Association
P.O. Box 28243
San Jose, CA 95159-8243
<http://www.sjaa.net/contact>

Place
postage
here

San Jose Astronomical Association
P.O. Box 28243
San Jose, CA 95159-8243

Fold here

San Jose Astronomical Association Annual Membership Form

P.O. Box 28243 San Jose, CA 95159-8243

Membership Type (must be 18 years or older):

☐ **New** ☐ **Renewal**

☐ **\$20** Regular Membership with online Ephemeris

☐ **\$30** Regular Membership with hardcopy Ephemeris mailed to below address

The newsletter is always available online at: <http://www.sjaa.net/sjaa-newsletter-ephemeris/>

Questions? Send e-mail to: memberships@sjaa.net

Bring this form to any SJAA Meeting or send to the address (above). Make checks payable to "SJAA", or join/renew at: <http://www.sjaa.net/join-the-sjaa/>

Name:

Address:

City/ST/Zip:

Phone:

E-mail address:

